with the local community. Some say this is quixotic repair work that leaves the original problem intact. What plagues the river is a deep rot, literally: take outfalls for allegedly 'treated' sewage, untreated industrial effluents with no allegations of purity, and thousands of illegal connections plugged into the AMC's stormwater network.

The city generates some 1,693 MLD of sewage. Its 14 sewage treatment plants (STPs) have a capacity of 1,252 MLD. Not more than 1,080 MLD is treated every day: the STPs go periodically into spells of dysfunctionality and maintenance mode. A 27 km mega pipeline is meant to route 120.8 MLD treated effluents from Narol, Naroda, Vatva and Odhav industrial estates, but the five Common Effluent Treatment Plants either do not function or fall short in capacity. Studies show high concentrations of organic pollutants and not enough oxygen for aquatic life. The effluents also seep into the groundwater, used to draw drinking water for nearly 500,000 homes.

"The unaccounted sewage isn't even routed through STPs," says environmental engineer Mahesh Pandya, who runs the NGO Paryavaran Mitra. Ahmedabad's urban sprawl is the issue: its population has doubled to 9 million since 2000, including the lakhs in the unserved ghettos. "But the trunk infrastructure has not caught up. It's a socio-political problem."

A 2021 suo motu PIL by the Gujarat High Court spurred some action. The AMC has introduced bioremediation—partially treating sewage using bacterial consortia—but missed its first deadline of March 1. Why all the new urgency? Put it down to the city's ambition is to emerge as a global sporting capital. The 2036 Olympics is on its mind. The river will be the cynosure of all eyes. ■



ANI

HAPPY FACE Omar Abdullah takes a selfie in Pahalgam, May 28

▶ KASHMIR

OMAR ON A SLED

The chief minister tries to revive Kashmir's tourism, as central forces secure Amarnath Yatra routes

By **Kaleem Geelani**

IT TOOK YEARS OF efforts. The Centre's push for better infrastructure, incentives to local industry and the sedulous dissemination of a feelgood narrative, helped by a dip in terrorism—it was an entire conspiracy of virtues that revived Jammu and Kashmir as a tourism hub. The Pahalgam terror attack ripped apart that patchwork quilt woven since 2019. The urgent question now is, how to revive that revival?

It's an unenviable task. As scared tourists stay away, summer hotel bookings are mostly cancelled, and large-scale layoffs in the hospitality sector are spreading misery.

Takeaways

- **As Kashmir faces a tourism chill, CM Omar Abdullah visits Pahalgam, asks for central compensation**
- **Union home minister Amit Shah visits Kashmir, holds security review for ongoing Amarnath yatra**

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah has clearly deemed the situation grim enough to lead a full countercharge, but he is seeking to do it with a touch of sunshine.

On May 27, he chose to hold a cabinet meeting right there on ground zero: Pahalgam. In the evening, he went on a cycle ride through its streets with sons Zahir and Zamir. Next day, cabinet in tow, the CM visited ski-resort Gulmarg, then took a cable car ride before the cameras. After Eid on June 7, the government will organise a Walkathon around Dal Lake in Srinagar and a water sports event on the lake.

A record 3.5 million tourists visited J&K in 2024; the sector adds 7 per cent to its GDP. Enthused locals, who invested in hotels and homestays, are unable to repay loans. The J&K government has petitioned the Centre to help these stakeholders.

Home minister Amit Shah, too, visited J&K on May 29-31. Agenda: to secure the Amarnath yatra that begins on July 3. A 50,000-strong detail will guard the routes to the cave, via Pahalgam and Ganderbal. There's zero tolerance for error. ■